

categories to locate a coupon for something I find on the clearance shelf. I can't do that with coupons downloaded on a phone or loaded onto a loyalty card.

These are the kind of problems UA PetSmart associate professor Anita Bhappu discovered when she studied digital coupons. The division chair of retailing and consumer sciences headed up a research project in 2010 that focused on grocery retailing with the use of digital coupons. Bhappu and her student researchers discovered that participants often found the coupons difficult to use. The team held focus groups and administered surveys before and after a one-week trial of digital coupons. The focus groups included heavy users of paper coupons, those Bhappu described as the "coupon divas," as well as non-users of paper coupons. The biggest complaint? After loading digital coupons onto loyalty cards, many could not remember which coupons were available to them.

Being able to see the saved coupons or have them show up automatically in a phone's grocery list application might make a difference in the ease of use. That is now a possibility. Applications like GroceryIQ and GroceryPal already make using digital coupons easier. The future holds even more possibility with a mobile technology company like PointInside that is developing and testing technology that will identify where a shopper is standing in a grocery store and offer that customer coupons based upon where they are and the products that are nearby. In other words, a future scenario might be a coupon program that will virtually nudge the consumer, urging them to purchase a particular product and offering them an incentive. (If you ask me, that sounds too much like taking a couple of kids along